

3rd Shot Drop

1. Lesson Recap

The 3rd shot drop is the soft shot the serving team often hits after the serve and return. The goal is not to win the point immediately. The goal is to neutralize the returning team's advantage at the kitchen line and give you and your partner time to move forward.

A good 3rd shot drop lands softly in or near the opponent's non-volley zone, also called the kitchen. When it drops low, your opponents have to hit up instead of attacking down.

2. Big Idea

The 3rd shot drop is a transition shot, not a winner.

Think: "soft, high enough, and unattackable." Your job is to buy time, move forward with control, and help your team get into the point.

3. Key Cues

- "Lift, don't hit."
- "Loose grip, soft hands."
- "Contact out front."
- "Low to high swing."
- "Peak on my side."
- "Make them hit up."
- "Move after a good drop."
- "Stay back if I pop it up."
- "Cross-court gives me more room."
- "Miss long before missing in the net."

4. Step-by-Step

1. Start balanced behind the baseline after you serve.
2. Read the return. If it is deep or heavy, give yourself time and do not rush.
3. Set your feet with knees soft and weight under control.
4. Hold the paddle with a relaxed grip. Keep the paddle face slightly open.
5. Let the ball drop into a comfortable contact zone, usually around knee to thigh height.
6. Contact the ball in front of your body with a smooth low-to-high motion.
7. Aim for a soft arc that clears the net and drops into the kitchen.
8. Prefer cross-court when possible because the court is longer and the net is lower in the middle.
9. After a good drop, move forward with your partner and be ready to split step.
10. If the drop is too high or attackable, stay back and prepare to defend or hit a better 5th shot drop.

5. Common Mistakes ⚠️

- Hitting too hard: The ball travels deep or sits up, giving opponents an easy attack. Loosen your grip and think “long dink” instead of drive.
- Swinging too big: A large backswing makes the shot harder to control. Keep the motion compact and smooth.
- Hitting down on the ball: A drop needs lift. Start below the ball and swing upward.
- Contacting the ball too late: Late contact often sends the ball into the net or off target. Try to meet the ball in front of your body.
- Rushing forward automatically: Only move in when your drop gives you time. If the ball is attackable, hold your ground and defend.
- Aiming too close to the net: Cutting it too fine causes net errors. Give yourself safe clearance while still trying to make the ball descend.

6. Self-Check ✅

- Am I using a relaxed grip?
- Am I contacting the ball in front of my body?
- Did I swing low to high?
- Did the ball peak on my side of the court?
- Did the ball make my opponent hit up?
- Was I balanced when I made contact?
- Did I move forward only after a good drop?
- Did I stay back when my drop was too high?
- Did I recover with my partner instead of rushing alone?

7. Homework 🏠

Practice these before your next play session:

- Ball-toss drop drill: Stand at the baseline without your paddle. Toss 20 balls underhand into the kitchen, aiming cross-court. Focus on soft arc, forward weight shift, and follow-through.
- Paddle drop reps: From the baseline, hit 30 gentle drops into the kitchen. Start with self-feeds, then use a partner feed if available.
- Cross-court target drill: Place a cone, towel, or paddle cover in the kitchen. Hit 20 drops toward the target from each side of the court.
- 3rd and move drill: Hit a drop, take two or three controlled steps forward, then split step. Do 10 reps focusing on balance after the shot.
- 3rd, 5th, 7th reset drill: With a partner, practice staying back after an attackable drop and trying again on the next ball. The goal is patience, not rushing forward.
- Game awareness task: During recreational play, notice whether your 3rd shot made the opponent hit up, attack, or take the ball out of the air comfortably.

8. Game Application 🎮

Use the 3rd shot drop when the return team is already at the kitchen line and you need time to move forward. Your target is usually the kitchen, especially cross-court or toward the opponent's weaker side.

Do not force the drop every time. If the return is short and high, a controlled drive may be a better choice. If the return pushes you deep or off balance, focus on making a safe shot and staying in the point.

In doubles, move with your partner. A good drop lets both players advance together. A weak drop means both players should be ready to defend and try again on the 5th or 7th shot.

9. Visualization 👁

Before you play, picture yourself serving deep and staying balanced behind the baseline. You see the return coming back. You set your feet, relax your grip, and let the ball drop into a comfortable spot.

Now imagine your paddle lifting smoothly through the ball. The ball rises softly, peaks on your side, clears the net, and lands in the kitchen. Your opponent reaches forward and has to hit up. You and your partner move forward together, split step, and feel ready for the next ball.

10. Quick Reminders 🏆

- Soft grip.
- Low to high.
- Contact in front.
- Aim for the kitchen, not the baseline.
- Make them hit up.
- Move forward after a good drop.
- Stay patient after a miss.
- If the drop is attackable, stay back and try again.

11. Resources

Use these resources for optional review away from the court. The lesson notes above are your main practice plan.

Articles

- [Pickleball third shot drop: How to hit it perfectly](#)
Source: PlayPickleball
A clear beginner-friendly explanation of what the 3rd shot drop is, why it matters, and how it helps the serving team get to the kitchen.
- [Master Your Third Shot Drop With The Perfect Height & Trajectory](#)
Source: PrimeTime Pickleball
Useful for understanding the arc of the ball, where the peak should be, and how to make opponents hit up.
- [Master the Third Drop Shot With Catherine Parenteau](#)
Source: Pickleball.com
Includes simple drills and pro-level reminders that are still practical for beginner and intermediate students.

YouTube Videos

- [Basic Third Shot Drop -- Building A Solid Foundation](#)
Channel: Sarah Ansboury
A strong fundamentals video for understanding the purpose, feel, and basic mechanics of the shot.
- [3rd Shot Success with Dave Weinbach | Pickleball](#)
Channel: PrimeTime Pickleball
Helpful for learning loose grip pressure, forward momentum, and when to stay back after a poor drop.
- [Pickleball 411: Improve Your Third Shot Drop with Wes Gabrielsen](#)
Channel: Pickleball Channel
Good visual explanation of ball flight and the soft touch needed to drop the ball into the kitchen.

Rules and Strategy References

- [USA Pickleball Rules Summary](#)
Review the two-bounce rule and non-volley zone basics. These rules explain why the serving team starts back and why a soft 3rd shot into the kitchen is so useful.
- [Complete Pickleball Rules Guide](#)
A broader rules overview that connects serving, the two-bounce rule, the kitchen, and court positioning.